

One War, Two Names

Lesson 8 — The consequences of 1948

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain why the same war is remembered under two different names

2

Describe the scale of Palestinian displacement and its long-term legal status

3

Explain why UN Resolution 194 remains unresolved decades later

4

Recognise a genuine historiographical shift: Israel's 'New Historians'

A war that ended, but resolved nothing

Lesson 7 ended with armistice lines replacing the UN's partition map. This lesson looks at what that war actually cost, and why its consequences remain unresolved to this day.

The War of Independence, and the Nakba

Israelis remember this conflict as the War of Independence — the war that secured the new state's survival against invading Arab armies. Palestinians remember it as the Nakba, Arabic for “catastrophe” — the mass displacement that ended, for most Palestinian Arabs, any presence in the land of their birth. Both names describe the same events; neither is simply wrong.

1948, by the numbers

700,000+

Palestinian Arabs displaced, per mainstream historical consensus

400+

Palestinian Arab towns and villages depopulated or destroyed

77–78%

Share of Mandate Palestine under Israeli control by 1949, versus 56% under the UN plan

Estimates of the exact number displaced range from roughly 520,000 to 1,000,000 across different sources; the true figure very likely exceeded 700,000.

UN Resolution 194, December 1948

The UN General Assembly called for refugees wishing to return to be permitted to do so, with compensation for those who chose not to. Israel's UN membership in May 1949 was formally conditioned on accepting this resolution — yet no large-scale return has occurred in the more than seven decades since, and the refugee question remains, by the UN's own description, one of the world's longest unresolved refugee crises.

UNRWA, established December 1949

Uniquely among the world's refugee populations, Palestinian refugees are served by their own dedicated UN agency, UNRWA, rather than the general UN refugee agency — a reflection of how the international community treated this crisis as a distinct, unresolved political question, not simply a humanitarian one to be closed out.

Israel's 'New Historians'

For decades after 1948, the dominant Israeli narrative held that Palestinians fled voluntarily, encouraged by Arab leaders. From the late 1970s, as Israeli military and government archives opened, a group of historians — among them Benny Morris — documented substantial, organised expulsion of Palestinian Arab civilians during the war, citing operational military plans and orders. This body of work, often called the “New Historians”, significantly revised the earlier narrative using newly available primary sources.

Documented events, disputed characterisation

Even historians drawing on the same archives disagree on what the evidence shows about intent: whether displacement resulted from a deliberate, pre-planned policy, or from decentralised decisions made amid the chaos of war. This is precisely the kind of historiographical debate — not about whether something happened, but about how to characterise and explain it — that a strong Paper 3 essay engages with directly, rather than avoiding.

A full essay attempt

'The consequences of the 1948 war made a future peaceful resolution between Israelis and Palestinians significantly harder to achieve.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence about displacement, UNRWA, and Resolution 194
- Address the strongest counter-argument before your conclusion

Key terms from today

Nakba

Arabic for “catastrophe”; the Palestinian name for the events of 1947–49.

UNRWA

The dedicated UN agency serving Palestinian refugees since 1949.

UN Resolution 194

December 1948 resolution calling for refugee return or compensation, never implemented.

New Historians

Israeli historians who, from the late 1970s, revised the dominant narrative using newly opened archives.

What to remember

The 1948 war produced one set of events remembered under two names, over 700,000 Palestinian Arabs displaced, and a refugee question the UN itself has never resolved. Israel's 'New Historians' substantially revised the dominant narrative from the late 1970s using newly opened archives — genuine historiographical debate that any strong essay on this period should engage with directly.

Lesson 9 — Egypt's monarchy crisis and the Free Officers

Next lesson turns to Egypt: how a discredited monarchy, weakened further by the 1948 war's outcome, fell to a group of army officers in 1952 — opening the era of Nasser and Arab nationalism.